

KNOCH MEDIA

Brand & *design system.*

Concept · Cinéma Vérité

Stakeholder document · v 1.0 · May 2026

Prepared for: Enoch Knoch, Founder

This document is the source of truth for visual identity, motion, copy voice, and component behavior across the Knoch Media digital experience. Any deviation should be reviewed against the principles laid out in §02.

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§ 01

Executive summary.

Knoch Media is a Maryland-based photography and film studio that, until now, has been presented online as a competent local service. This document outlines the brand and design system for the next iteration of `knochmedia.com` — a site engineered to attract and convert clients with budgets above \$5,000.

The chosen creative direction is **Cinéma Vérité**. The concept positions Knoch not as a wedding photographer who also shoots video, but as a filmmaker whose subject matter happens to include weddings, brand campaigns, and live events. The website itself performs the work it sells — it doesn't describe Enoch's eye, it gives the visitor an experience of it.

Three things this system is asking the visitor to feel:

- **Anticipation.** From the first frame, the site moves with the pacing of a film opening. Type loads like a credit sequence; nothing is rushed.
- **Reverence.** Imagery is treated as cinema, not content. Heavy contrast, controlled grain, frames numbered like slates. The work is the point.
- **Decisiveness.** Scarcity is real, language is direct, the booking flow is short. Premium clients are not asked to think twice.

The goal is not a portfolio site. The goal is a film festival entry that happens to include a contact form.

— CREATIVE DIRECTION · CONCEPT BRIEF

§ 02

Brand foundation.

Positioning

Knoch Media is the East Coast's working studio for clients who want their day, their brand, or their event captured the way a director would capture it — with a frame, a cut, and a point of view.

The single sentence

If the brand had to live in one sentence on a wall, it would be:

| **Nothing staged. Everything remembered.**
— BRAND LINE

Three principles

These are non-negotiable. They apply to every design decision, copy decision, and motion decision in the system.

01 · The work is the hero. Always.

If a design choice competes with the imagery for attention, the design choice loses. Type, motion, and chrome are servants of the photograph. This is why the site uses no decorative gradients, no illustrative iconography, and no "about" content above the first photograph.

02 · Restraint is the flex.

The brand asserts confidence by removing things, not adding them. Three nav links, two type families, one accent color. When in doubt, take something away. Empty space is not dead space — it is the room the work breathes in.

03 · Pacing is content.

Speed and silence are part of the message. A frame that holds for two seconds carries more weight than five frames that flicker by. The site's tempo — slow scrolls,

deliberate cuts, scrub-controlled timelines — tells visitors what kind of attention this work deserves before they read a single word.

Audience

This system is engineered for two audiences in priority order:

- **Primary:** Brand directors, creative leads, and agency producers commissioning campaign or editorial work between \$5,000 and \$50,000. They have seen good websites and will recognize when one is competent.
- **Secondary:** Couples planning weddings between \$4,000 and \$15,000 who are vetting photographers from a Pinterest board, not a Google search. They are looking for taste, not a price list.

What this system is **not** optimized for: high-volume, low-budget enquiries from buyers who compare on price. The chrome, language, and lack of pricing are deliberate filters.

§ 03

Visual identity.

Wordmark

The wordmark is set in the brand serif at body weight, lowercase, with an amber period locked to the baseline of the final letter:

Knoch.

PRIMARY LOCKUP

The period is the brand's only embellishment. It functions as a visual full stop — a literal mark of finality that echoes the studio's editorial confidence. Never replace it with another character, color, or animation.

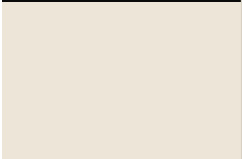
Don'ts

- Never set the wordmark in all caps.
- Never substitute a sans-serif. The serif is doing brand work; replacing it removes the warmth.
- Never animate the period independently.
- Never lock the wordmark inside a box, badge, or roundel.
- Minimum render size: 14px on screen, 11pt in print.

Color palette

Five tokens. That is the full palette. There is no "secondary" palette and no extended swatch set. Restraint is the brand.

	NAME / HEX	ROLE	USAGE NOTES
	Ink	Primary surface	The default background.

	#0A0A0A		Pure depth — never softened to grey.
	Paper #EDE6D8	Primary text	Warm, slightly off-white. Reads as paper, not as a UI white.
	Amber #E8A23A	Sole accent	Used for live indicators, scarcity, and timecode. Once per fold maximum.
	Rust #7A2418	Reserved	Reserved for editorial moments — appears once across the entire site.
	Muted #8C8C8C	Tertiary text	Captions, metadata, secondary chrome. Never used at body size.

Color rules

- **Amber appears once per visible viewport.** If two amber elements compete in a single fold, one of them is wrong.
- **Never combine amber and rust in the same view.** Rust is the brand's punctuation — it appears alone, in a moment of editorial weight.
- **All body copy is paper on ink.** Inverted lockups (ink on paper) exist only for the inquiry confirmation screen.
- **Avoid mid-greys.** Use Muted at 100% opacity, or use Paper at a lower opacity. Never introduce a fourth grey.

Typography

Two families. One for emotional weight. One for information. Their roles do not cross over.

Display — Fraunces (or equivalent contemporary serif)

Used for: headlines, project titles, pull quotes, the wordmark.

Fraunces is a high-contrast contemporary serif with a hint of warmth in its italic. The italic is doing meaningful work in this system — it appears wherever the brand wants to lean in emotionally.

Nothing staged.
*Everything
remembered.*

Mono — JetBrains Mono

Used for: timecode, frame numbers, metadata, slate captions, the recording indicator, phone numbers, and the booking form.

Monospace is the system's diegetic voice — it stands in for the language of cinema (timecode, slate, frame counts) and the language of contracts (form fields, phone, email). When data appears, it appears in mono. Always.

FRAME 12 / 36 · F / 2.0 · 1 / 250S · ISO
400

Type scale

TOKEN	SIZE	LINE- HEIGHT	USAGE
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Display XL	156px / 9.5vw	0.92	Hero only. One per page maximum.
Display L	96px	0.95	Section headlines. Pinned-section titles.
Display M	64px	1.05	Project titles. Quote setting.
Display S	32px	1.15	Card titles, section dividers.
Body	16px	1.6	Long-form copy, descriptions.
Caption	13px	1.5	Project sub-titles, attributions.
Mono	11px / 0.25em	1.4	Timecode, metadata, frame counts.
Eyebrow	10px / 0.3em	1.4	Section labels, scarcity tag.

Typography rules

- Italic is reserved for emotional weight (always in amber for headlines) — never for emphasis on body copy.
- Letter-spacing is loose on display (-0.02 to -0.04em) and tight-tracked on mono and eyebrows (+0.2 to +0.3em).
- Sentence case everywhere except mono labels and eyebrows. No title case.
- Two weights only: 300 (display) and 500 (mono, eyebrows).
- Long-form body is set in Inter at 16px, never below.

Image treatment

Photography on this site is not displayed; it is **graded**. Every image passes through a consistent treatment so the portfolio reads as a single body of work, not a collection of files.

Treatment recipe

SATURATION	−15% baseline. −30% on default state, restored on hover.
CONTRAST	+10% to +15%. Pulls highlights up, deepens the blacks.
BRIGHTNESS	0.85 default, 1.0 on hover or in the loupe interaction.
GRAIN OVERLAY	8% noise SVG, animated at 24fps over the entire viewport.
HALATION	2px warm-amber glow on highlights above 90% brightness.
ASPECT RATIO	Default 3:2 (35mm). 16:9 reserved for film stills only.
FILE FORMAT	AVIF with WebP fallback. JPEG only as last resort.

What never happens to an image

- No drop shadows. Ever.
- No rounded corners. Photographs have hard edges.
- No borders, except the optional thin rule used on the slate-style cards.
- No filters that simulate other film stocks (Polaroid, Lomo, etc.) — the grading is the look.
- No stock imagery, ever. If a photograph is on the site, it was shot by Knoch.

§ 04

Motion system.

The Knoch site is built around the idea that **the entire experience is a film**. This is not metaphor. It is a constraint on every animation decision.

First principles

01 · Sections cut. They do not transition.

Where most websites use fades or slides between sections, this site uses film cuts. A 1-frame white flash (16ms) precedes every major section change. Visitors will not consciously notice it; they will feel it as cinematic pacing.

02 · Scroll is the lever, not the scrollbar.

The site uses Lenis for smooth scrolling at a damping value of 0.06. The signature reel section is pinned and scrubbed — scrolling advances the timeline like winding a Bolex. The lag (scrub: 0.6–0.8) is intentional. It feels mechanical.

03 · Velocity is content.

When scroll velocity exceeds 2px/ms, hero imagery picks up motion blur (CSS filter, 4px). Stop scrolling, blur clears in 200ms. This forces visitors to slow down and engages the scroll as a physical input, not a navigation tool.

04 · The cursor is part of the system.

The default cursor is replaced with a 24px amber circle. On interactive elements it scales to 80px with a soft amber tint. The crosshair inside the circle echoes a camera viewfinder. This is the brand's most consistent visual signature — it is present on every page, every state.

Easing tokens

All animations use one of four easing curves. No ad-hoc easings.

TOKEN	GSAP NAME	WHEN TO USE
Reveal	expo.out	Type entering frame. Hero lines on

		load. Section reveals on scroll.
Settle	power3.out	Cards lifting into place. Modal entrances. Cursor scaling.
Cut	power2.inOut	Section transitions. Page state changes. Filter morphs.
Drift	none / linear	Parallax, scrubbed timelines, subtle continuous motion.

Duration scale

TOKEN	MS	WHEN TO USE
Snap	200ms	Hover state changes. Cursor scaling. Form field focus.
Beat	400ms	Underline fills, micro-transitions, secondary reveals.
Phrase	800ms	Section reveals, image grades, primary state changes.
Sequence	1200ms	Hero load, full-card transitions, signature reveals.
Reel	2400ms+	Scrub-controlled timelines, parallax, ambient motion.

Signature interactions

These are the moments the site is remembered for. They are non-negotiable in any iteration of the build.

01 · The opening sequence

On first load, the site presents a 1.8-second loader counting from 00 to 36 in the brand serif at 18vw ("36 exposures"). This is followed by a staggered hero reveal: meta line fades in (800ms), background un-zooms from 1.1 to 1.0 (2400ms), each headline line lifts from clip-mask in 120ms intervals, sub-line fades in last.

This sequence is the brand's hello. It must not be skipped, accelerated, or replaced with a static state.

02 · The horizontal reel

The work section is a pinned ScrollTrigger that converts vertical scroll into horizontal travel across six selected projects. Each card carries slate-style metadata (FRAME, SCENE, SHOT). Inside the horizontal scroll, each image runs an additional micro-parallax via containerAnimation.

This is the site's signature moment. It tells the visitor, within the first 40 seconds, that this is not a normal portfolio.

03 · The pinned counter

After the reel, a pinned section holds while three statistics count up from 00 to their final values (47 projects, 12,884 frames, 6 dates left). Counters use power3.out over 2200ms, triggered when the section enters the viewport. The background image parallaxes simultaneously.

04 · Hover reveal on portfolio grid

Each tile in the asymmetric grid runs a parallax internally (-8% to +8% Y on scrub). On hover, the image grade restores from desaturated/dim to full color/full brightness over 700ms, while the metadata label slides up from below with a gradient backdrop. The custom cursor scales to 80px and softly tints amber.

05 · The button fill

The primary CTA button (Begin an inquiry) fills from bottom to top with amber on hover. The fill uses ease(0.7, 0, 0.3, 1) over 500ms — sharp at the start, slow at the end, a curve borrowed from a film projector slowing to a still.

§ 05

Copy & voice.

Voice characteristics

Direct

Short sentences. Active verbs. No qualifying phrases ("It's worth noting that...", "We believe that..."). The voice is confident enough to make claims without hedging.

Editorial, not corporate

Reads like a director's note, not a service page. Uses first person. Punctuation is deliberate. Em-dashes are encouraged. Oxford commas, always.

Emotionally intelligent

Knows when to land a feeling and when to step out of the way. Saves italicized emotional words for moments that deserve them — not as decoration, but as emphasis.

Headline patterns

Three sentence patterns that consistently work for this brand:

Pattern A — The contradiction

Two short statements that frame each other. Read like a manifesto fragment.

Examples: "Nothing staged. Everything remembered." · "Eight years. Twelve thousand frames."

Pattern B — The list of three

Three short noun phrases that establish scope through subtraction.

Examples: "Forty weddings a year. A handful of brands. Nothing else."

Pattern C — The instructional

A direct verb-phrase invitation. Used for CTAs and section labels.

Examples: "Begin an inquiry." · "Make a roll." · "Request the catalog."

Approved copy library

These strings are signed off and may be used verbatim across the site, marketing, and proposals. Any change requires brand review.

Hero

Nothing staged. Everything remembered.

Cinematic photography & film · Maryland, available East Coast

Interlude (about)

"I don't photograph weddings. I attend them — quietly — and bring back what was beautiful."

— Enoch Knoch, Founder

Section labels

- Selected work.
- The studio · by the numbers.
- The archive.

CTA

Six dates left · 2026

Let's make a roll.

A 15-minute call tells us if we're a fit. No pressure, no hard sell, no auto-responders. Every inquiry gets a personal reply within 24 hours.

Begin an inquiry →

Words and phrases to avoid

- **"Storyteller at heart."** Used by every photographer with a website. Banned.

- **"Capturing your special day."** Generic. Has no point of view.
- **"We don't have one fixed style."** This currently appears on the live site three times. It signals "I'll be whatever you need" — premium clients hire a vision, not a chameleon.
- **"Affordable" / "flexible" / "versatile."** All three downgrade the brand. Pricing is communicated through scarcity language, not value language.
- **Exclamation points.** Banned site-wide. The brand is not excited. The brand is certain.

Component library.

Each component below has a clear job, a defined behavior, and a strict set of constraints. If a use-case isn't covered here, it doesn't exist yet — flag it for review.

01 · Fixed chrome

The persistent UI shell that wraps every page. Includes the wordmark (top-left), three-link nav (top-center), live REC indicator with timecode (top-right), and the timecode bar at the bottom with scroll progress and a frame counter.

POSITION	Fixed top + bottom. mix-blend-mode: difference applied so it adapts to imagery beneath.
NAV LINKS	Three only: Work · Studio · Inquire. Underline animates left-to-right on hover (400ms, expo.out).
REC INDICATOR	6px amber dot, pulse animation 1.6s ease-in-out infinite. Mono caps timecode counts up live from page load.
FRAME COUNTER (BOTTOM)	FRAME 01 / 36 — increments on scroll position globally, not per-section.
SCROLL PROGRESS	1px hairline rule, fills with amber based on document scroll progress.
PADDING	28px / 36px on desktop. 18px / 20px on mobile.

02 · Hero block

The opening frame of the experience. One per page maximum. Always full-viewport height, never less. Background imagery is treated (saturation –15%, brightness 0.45 baseline), with a radial vignette and an animated grain SVG layer at 18% opacity.

HEADLINE	Display XL, weight 300. Italicized words are amber. Each line wrapped in clip-mask reveal on load.
EYEBROW	Mono, amber, all caps, 0.3em tracking. Loads first.

ABOVE HEADLINE	
SUB LINE BELOW HEADLINE	Mono, paper at 60% opacity, 0.25em tracking. Loads last.
BACKGROUND	Full-bleed image, scale: 1.1 → 1.0 over 2400ms on load, parallax 25% on scroll-out.
LOADER	1.8s pre-hero load with 00 → 36 counter. Cannot be skipped.
CTA PLACEMENT	Hero never contains a primary CTA button. The first CTA appears only after the work section.

03 · Reel card (signature)

A slate-styled project card used inside the horizontal-scroll reel. Each card is exactly 38vw wide and 70vh tall. Always carries: frame number (top-left), four corner ticks (decorative slate marks), full-bleed treated image, scene label, project title, sub.

WIDTH / HEIGHT	38vw / 70vh. Margin-right: 3vw between cards.
IMAGE GRADE — DEFAULT	Saturation –30%, brightness 0.85, scale 1.15.
IMAGE GRADE — HOVER	Full color, brightness 1.0, scale 1.05. Transition 800ms.
SLATE CORNERS	18×18px, 1px paper rule, top-left/right/bottom-left/right. Decorative only.
FRAME NUMBER	Top-left, mono caps, paper, 0.2em tracking.
TITLE BLOCK	Bottom 24px, with linear-gradient(180deg, transparent 50%, ink 100%) backing.
INTERNAL PARALLAX	Image translates X: +40px → –40px on horizontal scrub.

04 · Portfolio tile (asymmetric grid)

A single image in the editorial 12-column grid on the archive section. Tiles vary in column-span and row-span to create a salon-style hang. Default state is desaturated and dimmed; hover reveals full grade and metadata label.

GRID	12 columns, 8vw row height, 1rem gap.
TILE SPANS	t1: 6 cols / 5 rows · t2-t3: 3 cols / 3 rows · t4: 6 cols / 2 rows · t5-t7: variable.
DEFAULT GRADE	Saturation –50%, brightness 0.7.
HOVER GRADE	Full color, brightness 1.0, image scales 1.04 over 1200ms.
METADATA LABEL	Slides up from +20px / opacity 0 to 0 / 1 over 600ms on hover. Backed by ink gradient.
Y PARALLAX	Image translates yPercent –8 → +8 across viewport via scrub.
STAGGER REVEAL	Each tile reveals on enter with 80px Y offset, 1200ms expo.out, 50ms stagger.

05 · Primary CTA

The site has one primary CTA pattern, used at the end of the homepage and the bottom of every project page. It carries scarcity, headline, sub, and button — in that order.

SCARCITY TAG	Amber rules either side, mono caps centered. Updates monthly with current available dates.
HEADLINE	Display XL, italicized accent in amber. Always two short lines or fewer.
SUB	Body, paper at 55% opacity, max-width 38ch.
BUTTON LABEL	Mono caps, 0.3em tracking. Always begins with a verb ("Begin", "Make", "Request").
BUTTON HOVER	Amber fills from bottom over 500ms with custom cubic-bezier. Text inverts to ink.
FORBIDDEN	Never two CTAs in the same view. Never use 'Submit', 'Send', or 'Click here'.

06 · Inquiry form

Multi-step, three screens. Step 1 qualifies the project. Step 2 collects identity. Step 3 confirms with a calendar link. The form is styled like a film order sheet — mono labels, paper backgrounds within the form fields, no rounded corners.

STEP 1 FIELDS	Project type (chips) · Date · Location · Investment range (chips) · Open note.
STEP 2 FIELDS	Name · Email · Phone · How you heard about Knoch.
STEP 3	Confirmation message + Calendly embed for a 15-minute call.
FIELD STYLE	1px paper rule on all sides, no fill. Active state: amber rule, paper at 8% opacity fill.
LABELS	Mono caps, 0.1em tracking, paper at 50% opacity, above field.
VALIDATION	Inline, amber. Never red. Errors phrased as suggestions, not warnings.
SUCCESS STATE	Inverts to paper background. Single line + Calendly. No animations beyond a simple fade.

Layout & grid.

Spacing scale

All spacing values are pulled from this scale. No half-step or arbitrary values.

TOKEN	VALUE	TYPICAL USE
xs	8px	Inline element gaps, icon padding.
s	16px	Stack gaps inside cards, form field padding.
m	24px	Card internal padding, label-to-field spacing.
l	48px	Section internal vertical rhythm.
xl	96px	Between major content blocks.
xxl	224px (14rem)	Top/bottom of major sections (portfolio, testimonial).

Page margins

- **Desktop:** 8vw left/right side padding on all sections except hero (full bleed).
- **Tablet:** 5vw, with grid collapsing from 12 to 8 columns.
- **Mobile:** 24px, grid fully collapses to single column. Custom cursor disables.

Breakpoints

Three breakpoints. Designs are produced at 1440 desktop and 390 mobile. Tablet is treated as the in-between, not a separate canvas.

- Desktop: 1024px and up
- Tablet: 800px – 1023px
- Mobile: below 800px

Vertical rhythm

Sections breathe. The site uses generous top and bottom padding (xxl = 224px) on major sections — this is non-negotiable, even when content feels short. Empty space is *earned* by the work; removing it diminishes everything else.

§ 08

Implementation notes.

Tech stack

FRAMEWORK	Astro or Next.js (App Router). Static generation preferred — no SSR needed for this content.
STYLING	Vanilla CSS with custom properties for tokens. No utility framework unless team strongly prefers.
ANIMATION	GSAP 3.12+ with ScrollTrigger plugin. Lenis 1.x for smooth scroll integration.
TYPE LOADING	Self-hosted via Fontsource or Vercel/Cloudflare. Never Google Fonts CDN in production.
IMAGE PIPELINE	AVIF + WebP via Astro Image / next/image. Sharp for build-time treatment LUT.
HOSTING	Vercel or Cloudflare Pages.
DOMAIN	knochmedia.com (acquire first). Redirect .xyz with 301.
CMS (OPTIONAL)	Sanity or Notion-as-CMS for project pages. Not required for v1.

Performance targets

- **Largest Contentful Paint:** under 2.0s on 4G.
- **Total page weight:** under 1.5MB on the homepage (excluding video).
- **Cumulative Layout Shift:** 0. The site uses fixed dimensions for every image and pinned section.
- **Hero load time:** the 1.8s loader is intentional brand experience, not unoptimized loading. The actual asset payload should resolve well before the loader completes.

Accessibility

The cinematic motion direction is aggressive by design. The implementation must be respectful of users who can't or don't want it.

- **prefers-reduced-motion:** disables every parallax, every scrub-controlled animation, every cursor effect. The site falls back to a clean static layout with simple opacity fades only.
- **Custom cursor:** hidden on touch devices and when reduced-motion is set. Native cursor is restored.
- **Color contrast:** Paper on Ink achieves 14.8:1 (AAA). Muted on Ink achieves 4.7:1 (AA Large). Mono labels never set below 11px.
- **Keyboard navigation:** All interactive elements reachable via Tab. Focus states use a 2px amber outline with 4px offset.
- **Semantic HTML:** h1 once per page. Every image has a meaningful alt that names the project, not just "wedding photo".

Browser support

Targeting evergreen browsers — Chrome, Safari, Firefox, Edge — last two versions. The site degrades gracefully on older Safari (mix-blend-mode, container queries) by losing ambient effects, never the underlying content or layout.

Asset checklist.

Items required from Enoch / Knoch Media before development can begin. Approval of this brand document presumes commitment to deliver these.

Photography

- Hero background — one full-bleed landscape, 2400×1600 minimum, color-treated.
- Six selected projects, fully edited galleries (15–25 images each, plus one cover).
- Twelve to twenty additional projects for the archive grid.
- One single "hero portrait" of Enoch for the studio page (optional but recommended).

Film / motion

- Hero ambient loop — 8-second silent video, 1920×1080, MP4/WebM, under 4MB.
- One trailer reel for the homepage "reel" section — 60–90 seconds, 1080p.
- Optional: B-roll for the about page if a talking-head sequence is desired.

Copy

- Approved interlude quote and signature. (Provided in §05; final wording confirmed.)
- Six project descriptions, 50–80 words each.
- One studio essay, 200–400 words, written in the brand voice.
- Three real testimonials with names, titles, and project types.

Brand assets

- Wordmark in SVG (Knoch + amber period) — to be designed alongside this document.

- Favicon — 32×32 amber period mark.
- Open Graph image — 1200×630, treated.

Operational

- knochmedia.com domain acquisition.
- Calendly link for the booking step.
- Final pricing tiers (internal, used to set the inquiry-form chips).
- Confirmed brand email — recommended: enoch@knochmedia.com (not team@).

§ 10

Approval & sign-off.

By signing below, the stakeholder confirms approval of the brand and design system as specified in this document. Approval covers visual identity, motion principles, copy voice, and component specifications. Implementation will reference this document as the source of truth.

Any changes after sign-off should be raised against this document version (v 1.0) and either accepted as a deviation (logged) or escalated to a v 1.1 revision.

STAKEHOLDER Enoch Knoch · Founder, Knoch Media <i>Signature</i>	DATE <i>Day · Month · Year</i>
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